Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ التَّوَّابِينَ وَيُحِبُّ الْمُتَطَهِّرِينَ

"Indeed, Allah loves those who repent and loves those who purify themselves." (al-Baqarah 2:222)

Ḥayḍ, Nifās and Istiḥāḍah

The Mālikī fiqh of menstruation, bleeding after childbirth and irregular bleeding: what each is, how long it lasts, and how to become pure.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Every Muslim woman's prayer, fasting, Qur'an and Ḥajj depend on knowing when she is in a state of purity and when she is not. Learning these rulings is therefore an obligation on every woman who has reached puberty, and it is important for men too: husbands, fathers, teachers and students of fiqh.

This is not a subject to be ashamed of. When ʿĀʾishah (raḍiyallāhu ʿanhā) was upset that her period began during Ḥajj, the Prophet ﷺ comforted her:

> إِنَّ هَذَا أَمْرٌ كَتَبَهُ اللَّهُ عَلَى بَنَاتِ آدَمَ
>
> **"This is something Allah has decreed for the daughters of Ādam."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (294) and Muslim (1211).

ʿĀʾishah also praised the women of the Anṣār: "How excellent were the women of the Anṣār! Shyness did not stop them from learning their religion" (Muslim, 332). They came to the Prophet ﷺ with their questions about these very matters.

How this guide works

The rulings follow **the Mālikī school**, as taught in its main texts: the Risālah of Ibn Abī Zayd al-Qayrawānī, al-Akhḍarī, al-ʿAshmāwiyyah and the Mukhtaṣar of Khalīl. Where the school's scholars differ on a detail, the guide gives the main (mashhūr) view and says so.

Practical sections speak to the reader directly. Sections marked **For students** add the terms and the evidence.

Bodies differ, and some situations are complicated. **Ask a qualified teacher** about any case this guide does not settle. If bleeding is unusual, very heavy or painful, **see a doctor** as well: a medical problem does not change the fiqh, but it matters for your health.

Contents

01 **Three kinds of bleeding**
Ḥayḍ, nifās and istiḥāḍah at a glance

02 **Ḥayḍ (menstruation)**
When it counts, how long it lasts, and how you know it has ended

03 **Nifās (bleeding after childbirth)**
Its length, when it stops early, and when it returns

04 **Istiḥāḍah (irregular bleeding)**
What it is, and how to pray and fast with it

05 **What changes, and what does not**
Forbidden acts, making up, and what is still allowed

06 **Prayer times, fasting and Ḥajj**
Which prayers you owe when bleeding starts or stops

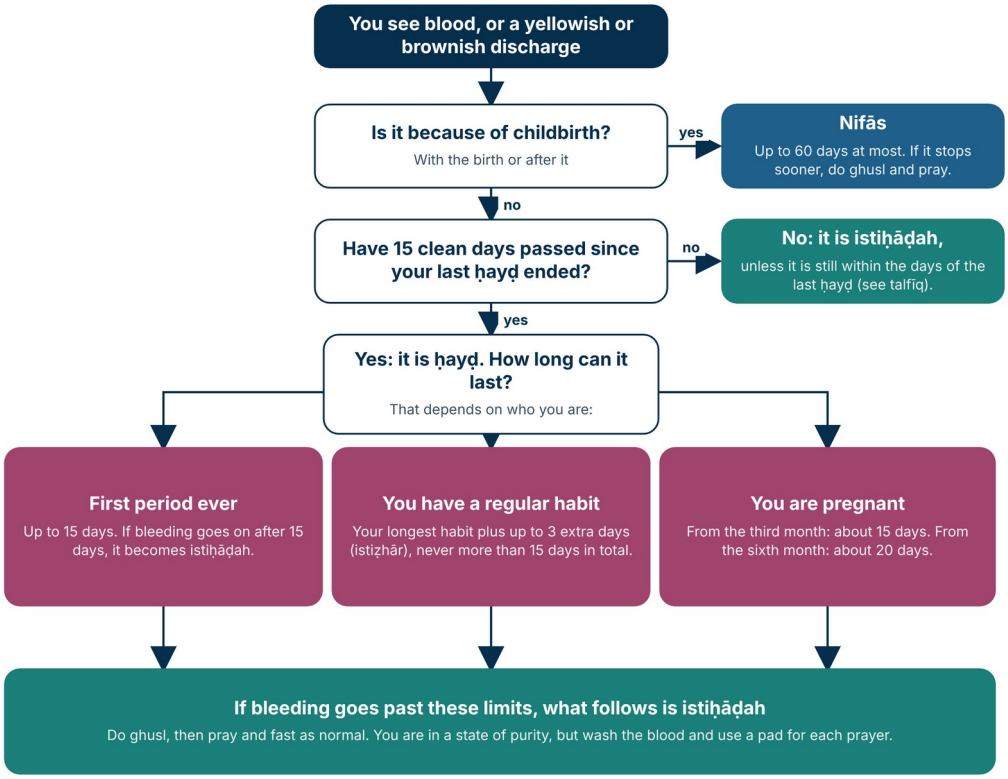
07 **Ghusl**
The obligatory and recommended acts, step by step

08 **Worked examples**
Eight real situations, solved

09 **For students, records and self-test**
Summary of numbers, evidence, monthly record and quiz

Is it ḥayḍ, nifās or istiḥāḍah?

A simple guide to the Mālikī rulings. Ask a teacher about anything unclear.



Bleeding ends when you see the white discharge (al-qaṣṣah al-bayḍā') or complete dryness (al-jufūf). Then do ghusl. Any bleeding at all is ḥayḍ for prayer and fasting, even a single gush, if it comes after 15 clean days.

Part 1 Three kinds of bleeding

	Ḥayḍ (menstruation)	Nifās (after childbirth)	Istiḥāḍah (irregular bleeding)
What it is	Natural bleeding from the womb at set times	Bleeding because of childbirth	Bleeding from an illness or a vein, outside the limits of ḥayḍ and nifās
Longest it can last	15 days (details in Part 2)	60 days	No limit
Prayer	Not prayed, and not made up	Not prayed, and not made up	Prayed as normal
Fasting	Not fasted; made up later	Not fasted; made up later	Fasted as normal
When it ends	Ghusl is obligatory	Ghusl is obligatory	No ghusl needed
Her state	Not in purity	Not in purity	In purity

وَيَسْأَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْمَحِيضِ ۖ قُلْ هُوَ أَذًى فَاعْتَزِلُوا النِّسَاءَ فِي الْمَحِيضِ ۖ وَلَا تَقْرَبُوهُنَّ حَتَّىٰ يَطْهُرْنَ

“They ask you about menstruation. Say: It is a harm, so keep away from women during menstruation, and do not approach them until they are pure.”

Al-Baqarah 2:222.

إِنَّمَا ذَلِكِ عِرْقٌ وَلَيْسَ بِالْحَيْضَةِ، فَإِذَا أَقْبَلَتِ الْحَيْضَةُ فَدَعِي الصَّلَاةَ، وَإِذَا أَدْبَرَتْ فَاغْسِلِي عَنْكِ الدَّمَ وَصَلِّي

“That is a vein, not ḥayḍ. When ḥayḍ comes, leave the prayer; and when it goes, wash the blood from yourself and pray.”

The Prophet ﷺ to Fāṭimah bint Abī Ḥubaysh, who had istiḥāḍah. Narrated by al-Bukhārī (228) and Muslim (333).

Part 2 Ḥayḍ (menstruation)

What counts as ḥayḍ

In the Mālikī school, ḥayḍ is **blood, or a yellowish (ṣufrah) or brownish (kudrah) discharge, that comes out by itself from the womb of a woman of an age to have children**, and not because of childbirth or illness. So a yellowish or brownish discharge that comes in place of the period, or within it, counts as ḥayḍ, just like red or dark blood.

Age

- **Before about nine years old**, bleeding is not ḥayḍ.
- **From about nine to thirteen**, and **from fifty to seventy**, experienced women are asked whether bleeding like this is a period.
- **From thirteen to fifty**, bleeding with the qualities of a period is ḥayḍ.
- **After seventy**, bleeding is not ḥayḍ.

How short can it be?

For prayer and fasting, ḥayḍ has **no minimum**. Even a single gush (dafʿah) of blood counts as ḥayḍ if it comes after a full period of purity: you leave the prayer while it lasts and do ghusl when it stops.

How long can it be? It depends who you are

Your situation	Longest ḥayḍ	What happens after that
First period ever (al-mubtadiʾah)	15 days	If bleeding continues past 15 days, it is istiḥāḍah: do ghusl and pray.
You have a habit (al-muʿtādah): your periods usually last a certain number of days	Your longest habit, plus up to **3 extra days of waiting** (istiẓhār), but never more than 15 days in total	If bleeding continues after that, it is istiḥāḍah: do ghusl and pray.
Pregnant, from the third month	About 15 days	After that, istiḥāḍah.
Pregnant, from the sixth month on	About 20 days	After that, istiḥāḍah.

Istiẓhār: waiting three extra days

If your period usually lasts 6 days and this time it carries on, you keep treating it as ḥayḍ for up to 3 more days (until day 9). If it stops before then, all of it was ḥayḍ. If it is still going after day 9, do ghusl and pray: what follows is istiḥāḍah.

The 3 days never take you past 15. A woman whose habit is 13 days waits only 2 more; a woman whose habit is 14 days waits 1; a woman whose habit is 15 does not wait at all.

If your habit changes from month to month, count from the longest of your recent habits.

For a pregnant woman before the third month, the scholars of the school differ: many treat her like a woman who is not pregnant. Ask a teacher if this applies to you.

The shortest time between two periods

The shortest period of purity (ṭuhr) between two periods is **15 days**. If bleeding returns before 15 clean days have passed, it is not a new period; it is either part of the same period (see talfīq below) or istiḥāḍah.

How you know your period has ended

Purity has two signs:

- **Al-qaṣṣah al-bayḍāʾ**: a white discharge that comes at the end of the period, like white thread.
- **Al-jufūf**: dryness. A piece of white cotton or tissue placed at the private part comes out dry, with no trace of blood, yellow or brown.

In the Mālikī school, the white discharge is the stronger sign. **If you normally see the white discharge**, and you see dryness first, wait for the white discharge until the end of the preferred time of the prayer you are in; if it has not come by then, dryness is enough. **If you normally only see dryness**, then dryness is enough, and so is the white discharge if you see it first. As soon as you see the sign of purity, do ghusl and pray.

لَا تَعْجَلْنَ حَتَّى تَرَيْنَ الْقَصَّةَ الْبَيْضَاءَ

“Do not hurry until you see the white discharge.”

ʿĀʾishah, to women who sent her cotton with traces of yellow; reported by al-Bukhārī (in the Book of Ḥayḍ) and by Mālik in al-Muwaṭṭaʾ.

When bleeding stops and starts (talfīq)

Sometimes bleeding comes for a day or two, stops, then comes back. In the Mālikī school, **the days of bleeding are added together (talfīq)**. On the clean days in between, you are pure: do ghusl, pray, fast, and so on. On the days of bleeding, you leave the prayer. You keep doing this until the days of bleeding add up to your maximum (15 for a first period, or your habit plus istiẓhār). After that, any further bleeding is istiḥāḍah.

Example of talfīq

Your habit is 5 days, so your maximum is 8 (5 + 3). You bleed 2 days, are clean 1 day, bleed 3 days, are clean 2 days, then bleed 4 more days. Count the bleeding days: 2 + 3 = 5, then 3 more of the last 4 days make 8. So the first 3 days of the final bleeding are ḥayḍ, and the 4th is istiḥāḍah. On each clean day, and after day 8 of bleeding, you do ghusl and pray.

Part 3 Nifās (bleeding after childbirth)

Nifās is **the blood that comes out because of childbirth**, with the birth or after it. Its rulings are the same as ḥayḍ: no prayer, no fasting, no intercourse, and ghusl when it ends.

Question	Mālikī ruling
Longest it can last	**60 days.** If bleeding continues after 60 days, do ghusl and pray: what follows is istiḥāḍah.
Shortest	**No minimum.** If the bleeding stops after a few days, or even on the day of the birth, do ghusl and pray. You do not have to wait 40 days.
It stops, then returns within 15 days	It is still nifās. Add the days of bleeding together (talfīq) up to 60, and pray on the clean days.
It returns after 15 clean days or more	It is a new ḥayḍ, not nifās.
Birth with no bleeding at all	There is no nifās. Ghusl is still required because of the birth, according to the view preferred in the school.
Miscarriage	If what comes out is the beginning of a child, even a clot of blood according to the school, the bleeding after it is nifās. If it is not, the bleeding is ḥayḍ or istiḥāḍah. Ask a teacher to apply this to your case.

Many people believe a woman must wait forty days after giving birth whatever happens. That is not the ruling in the school: when bleeding stops and you see the sign of purity, your nifās has ended, even if it is only a week.

Part 4 Istiḥāḍah (irregular bleeding)

Istiḥāḍah is **bleeding that is not ḥayḍ or nifās**: bleeding that continues past the limits above, or that comes before 15 clean days have passed since the last period, or that is caused by illness. The Prophet ﷺ called it "a vein".

The ruling: you are in a state of purity

- You **pray, fast, recite the Qur'an, enter the mosque and make ṭawāf** as normal.
- Intercourse with your husband is **permitted**.
- You do **not** need ghusl for each prayer. Do ghusl once, when your ḥayḍ or nifās has ended and the istiḥāḍah begins.

Prayer with istiḥāḍah

1. Before each prayer, wash away the blood and use a pad or cloth to hold it back.
2. **If the bleeding is with you more of the time than not**, it does not break your wuḍūʾ, but making wuḍūʾ for each prayer is recommended.
3. **If it stops more of the time than it comes**, it breaks wuḍūʾ like any other discharge, so make wuḍūʾ after it.
4. Then pray, even if blood comes out during the prayer. Your prayer is valid.

Telling ḥayḍ apart from istiḥāḍah (tamyīz)

A woman with long-lasting istiḥāḍah may later see bleeding that is clearly different: darker, thicker or with the smell of a period. If this happens **after 15 days of istiḥāḍah**, which count as days of purity, that changed blood is **ḥayḍ**, and she leaves the prayer. If she cannot tell any difference, she stays in a state of purity and keeps praying.

> **"The blood of ḥayḍ is dark blood that is recognised."**
>
> The Prophet ﷺ to Fāṭimah bint Abī Ḥubaysh; narrated by Abū Dāwūd (286) and an-Nasāʾī.

Part 5 What changes during ḥayḍ and nifās

Act	Ruling	Make it up?
Prayer	Forbidden	**No**
Fasting	Forbidden	**Yes**, after Ramaḍān
Ṭawāf around the Kaʿbah	Forbidden	Done after purity
Intercourse, and enjoyment between the navel and the knee	Forbidden until **ghusl** is done, not only until the bleeding stops	
Touching the muṣḥaf	Forbidden, except for a teacher or a student who needs it for learning (Mālikī)	
Staying in the mosque and iʿtikāf	Forbidden	
Divorce	Forbidden for the husband to pronounce while she is in ḥayḍ or nifās	
Reciting the Qur'an from memory	**Allowed while bleeding** (Mālikī), but not after the bleeding stops and before ghusl	

كَانَ يُصِيبُنَا ذَلِكَ، فَنُؤْمَرُ بِقَضَاءِ الصَّوْمِ وَلَا نُؤْمَرُ بِقَضَاءِ الصَّلَاةِ

"That used to happen to us, and we were commanded to make up the fasts but not commanded to make up the prayers."

ʿĀʾishah, narrated by Muslim (335).

What is still allowed

- **Dhikr, duʿāʾ, istighfār**, sending ṣalāh on the Prophet ﷺ, and reading books of tafsīr, ḥadīth and fiqh.
- **Going to the ʿĪd prayer ground** to hear the khuṭbah and join the duʿāʾ, staying away from the prayer rows (al-Bukhārī, 324).
- **All the rites of Ḥajj except ṭawāf** (al-Bukhārī, 305).
- **Normal family life**: cooking, eating together, sitting together. The Prophet ﷺ would drink from the place on the cup where ʿĀʾishah had drunk while she was menstruating (Muslim, 300), and would recite the Qur'an resting in her lap (al-Bukhārī, 297).

There is no basis for the belief that a woman in ḥayḍ must not cut her hair or nails, must not cook, or must stay apart from her family.

When your period ends near the end of a prayer time

If you become pure while some of a prayer's time remains, you must pray it if there is time to **do ghusl and pray at least one rakʿah** before the time ends. Ẓuhr and ʿAṣr share a time until sunset, and Maghrib and ʿIshāʾ share a time until dawn, so:

You become pure…	Time left after doing ghusl	You must pray
Before sunset	Enough for 5 rakʿahs or more	Ẓuhr and ʿAṣr
Before sunset	Enough for 1 to 4 rakʿahs	ʿAṣr only
Before dawn (Fajr)	Enough for 4 rakʿahs or more	Maghrib and ʿIshāʾ
Before dawn (Fajr)	Enough for 1 to 3 rakʿahs	ʿIshāʾ only
Before sunrise	Enough for 1 rakʿah	Fajr

When your period starts during a prayer time

If your period starts before you have prayed, while the same amount of time remains (counted without ghusl), you are excused from that prayer and do not make it up. For example, if bleeding starts when there is enough time left before sunset for 5 rakʿahs, neither Ẓuhr nor ʿAṣr is owed. If it starts with time for fewer than 5 but at least 1, ʿAṣr is dropped and Ẓuhr must be made up. Do not delay prayers without need: if you had time to pray and did not, ask a teacher what you owe.

For students

This follows the Mālikī principle that a prayer is "caught" (mudrak) by one rakʿah within its time, and that the last part of a shared time belongs to the second prayer. For a woman becoming pure, the time needed for ghusl is counted; for one whose period begins, it is not.

Fasting

- **If you become pure before dawn**, intend to fast and fast that day, even if you do the ghusl after dawn.
- **If your period starts during the day**, even moments before sunset, that day's fast is broken and you make it up.
- **If you become pure during the day**, you make up that day. In the Mālikī school you are not required to stop eating for the rest of the day, but be discreet.
- Make up missed fasts before the next Ramaḍān. Keep a record (see the record page).

Ḥajj and ʿUmrah

> افْعَلِي مَا يَفْعَلُ الْحَاجُّ، غَيْرَ أَنْ لَا تَطُوفِي بِالْبَيْتِ حَتَّى تَطْهُرِي
>
> **“Do everything the pilgrim does, except do not make ṭawāf of the House until you are pure.”**
>
> The Prophet ﷺ to ʿĀʾishah, narrated by al-Bukhārī (305).

You may enter iḥrām, stand at ʿArafah, stay at Muzdalifah and Minā and stone the jamarāt. The ṭawāf of ifāḍah waits until you are pure. The farewell ṭawāf is excused for a woman in ḥayḍ or nifās (al-Bukhārī, 1755).

Part 7 Ghusl: becoming pure

The obligatory acts (farāʾiḍ) in the Mālikī school

1. **Intention (niyyah)**: intend to lift the state of ḥayḍ or nifās, at the start of the ghusl.
2. **Water over the whole body** (taʿmīm), including the hair and skin underneath it.
3. **Rubbing (dalk)**: passing the hand over the body with the water. This is obligatory in the Mālikī school.
4. **Continuity (muwālāh)**: doing it all in one go, without a long break, as long as you remember and are able.
5. **Running water through the hair and between the fingers** (takhlīl).

The sunnahs

- Washing the hands to the wrists first.
- Rinsing the mouth (maḍmaḍah).
- Sniffing water into the nose and blowing it out (istinshāq and istinthār).
- Wiping the inner holes of the ears.

The recommended way, step by step

1. Say “bismillāh” and wash your hands.
2. Wash away any blood from the private part with your left hand, with the intention of ghusl.
3. Make a complete wuḍūʾ, as for prayer.
4. Pour water over your head three times, working it into the roots of the hair.
5. Wash the right side of the body, then the left, from top to bottom, rubbing as you go.
6. Check the hidden places: behind the ears, the navel, under the arms, behind the knees, between the toes.

Braided hair: you do not have to undo braids if water reaches the roots of the hair and the scalp; if the braids are so tight that water cannot reach, undo them (Muslim, 330, from Umm Salamah). After ghusl, it is recommended to use a piece of cloth or cotton with perfume to remove the traces of blood (al-Bukhārī, 314).

Part 8 Worked examples

Example 1. Maryam, 12, gets her first period. It lasts 18 days.

Her first 15 days are ḥayḍ. At the end of day 15 she does ghusl and prays; days 16 to 18 are istiḥāḍah, and she prays and fasts as normal.

Example 2. Fāṭimah's period always lasts 6 days. This month it is still going on day 7.

She waits up to 3 extra days. If it stops on day 8, all 8 days were ḥayḍ. If it is still going on day 10, she does ghusl at the end of day 9 and prays; the rest is istiḥāḍah.

Example 3. Khadījah's habit is 13 days. Bleeding continues.

She waits only 2 extra days, up to 15. On day 16 she does ghusl and prays.

Example 4. Ruqayyah sees bleeding 10 days after her last period ended.

Fewer than 15 clean days have passed, so it is not a new period. If her last period had not reached its maximum, it is added to it (talfīq); otherwise it is istiḥāḍah, and she keeps praying.

Example 5. Āminah's period seems to stop on day 4. She sees dryness, but she normally sees the white discharge.

She waits for the white discharge until the end of the preferred time of the prayer she is in. If it has not come by then, dryness is enough: she does ghusl and prays.

Example 6. Ḥafṣah gives birth. The bleeding stops on day 12.

Her nifās has ended. She does ghusl and prays from day 12; she does not wait 40 days. If bleeding returns on day 20 (within 15 days), it is still nifās, counted together up to 60.

Example 7. Zaynab is seven months pregnant and sees bleeding.

From the sixth month, ḥayḍ during pregnancy can last about 20 days. She leaves the prayer while it lasts, up to about 20 days; after that, it is istiḥāḍah.

Example 8. Sumayyah becomes pure 20 minutes before sunset. Ghusl takes her 10 minutes.

After ghusl she has about 10 minutes, enough for at least 5 rakʿahs, so she prays both Ẓuhr and ʿAṣr.

Part 9 For students: the numbers and the terms

Rule	Mālikī position
Minimum ḥayḍ	None for worship: a single gush (dafʿah)
Maximum ḥayḍ, first-timer	15 days
Maximum ḥayḍ, woman with a habit	Longest habit + istiẓhār of 3 days, not beyond 15
Maximum ḥayḍ, pregnant	From the 3rd month about 15 days; from the 6th about 20
Minimum purity between two periods	15 days
Maximum nifās	60 days
Minimum nifās	None
Signs of purity	Al-qaṣṣah al-bayḍāʾ (stronger) and al-jufūf
Intermittent bleeding	Talfīq: days of bleeding are added together; clean days are purity
Ṣufrah and kudrah	Count as ḥayḍ

Term	Meaning
Ḥayḍ	Menstruation.
Nifās	Bleeding because of childbirth.
Istiḥāḍah	Bleeding outside the limits of ḥayḍ and nifās; a woman with it is a mustaḥāḍah.
Ṭuhr	Purity; the time between two periods.
Mubtadiʾah	A girl or woman having her first period.
Muʿtādah	A woman with an established habit.
Istiẓhār	Waiting up to 3 extra days beyond the habit.
Talfīq	Adding together the days of bleeding when bleeding is intermittent.
Tamyīz	Telling ḥayḍ apart from istiḥāḍah by the blood's colour, thickness or smell.
Al-qaṣṣah al-bayḍāʾ	The white discharge that marks the end of the period.
Al-jufūf	Dryness at the end of the period.
Ṣufrah, kudrah	Yellowish and brownish discharge.

Record My monthly record

Keep a private record so you know your habit, can apply the rulings, and can track fasts you need to make up. Write the dates in the Islamic or the ordinary calendar, whichever you use.

Month	Started	Stopped	Days	Sign of purity	Notes
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					

Fasts to make up

Ramaḍān of year	Days missed	Days made up (tick each)	Done
		☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐
		☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐
		☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer, according to the Mālikī school. The answers follow.

1. What is the longest a first period can last?

a) 10 days b) 15 days c) 20 days d) 40 days

2. Your habit is 7 days and the bleeding continues. Up to which day do you treat it as ḥayḍ?

a) Day 7 b) Day 10 c) Day 15 d) Day 14

3. What is the shortest period of purity between two periods?

a) 5 days b) 10 days c) 15 days d) 30 days

4. A yellowish discharge in the days of your period is:

a) Ḥayḍ b) Istiḥāḍah c) Nothing d) Nifās

5. What is the longest nifās can last?

a) 40 days b) 50 days c) 60 days d) 90 days

6. Your nifās stops on day 10. What do you do?

a) Do ghusl and pray b) Wait until day 40 c) Wait until day 60 d) Pray without ghusl

7. Which do you make up after your period?

a) The fasts only b) The prayers only c) Both d) Neither

8. When does intercourse become permitted after a period?

a) After ghusl b) As soon as bleeding stops c) After 3 days d) After the next prayer

9. A woman with istiḥāḍah:

a) Prays and fasts as normal b) Leaves the prayer c) Must do ghusl for every prayer d) Cannot fast

10. Which sign of purity is stronger in the Mālikī school?

a) The white discharge b) Dryness c) Both are equal d) Neither

11. Bleeding comes on and off. What do you do on the clean days?

a) Do ghusl and pray b) Wait c) Pray without ghusl d) Make up the prayers later

12. You become pure 15 minutes before sunset; after ghusl there is time for 5 rakʿahs. What do you pray?

a) Ẓuhr and ʿAṣr b) ʿAṣr only c) Nothing d) Maghrib

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) 15 days	7	a) The fasts only
2	b) Day 10 (7 + 3)	8	a) After ghusl
3	c) 15 days	9	a) Prays and fasts as normal
4	a) Ḥayḍ	10	a) The white discharge
5	c) 60 days	11	a) Do ghusl and pray
6	a) Do ghusl and pray	12	a) Ẓuhr and ʿAṣr

For further study

- **Matn al-Akhḍarī**, the chapter on ḥayḍ and nifās, with a teacher's explanation.
- **Al-Muqaddimah al-ʿAshmāwiyyah**, the chapters on ghusl, ḥayḍ and nifās.
- **Ar-Risālah** of Ibn Abī Zayd al-Qayrawānī, the chapter on ḥayḍ, istiḥāḍah and nifās.
- **Mukhtaṣar Khalīl** with its commentaries, for advanced students.

Duʿāʾ After purification

اللَّهُمَّ اجْعَلْنِي مِنَ التَّوَّابِينَ، وَاجْعَلْنِي مِنَ الْمُتَطَهِّرِينَ

"O Allah, make me among those who repent, and make me among those who purify themselves."

Said after wuḍūʾ; narrated by at-Tirmidhī (55).

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